

INDEPENDENT RESEARCH IN PROGRESS

Identity Hygiene as Outcome Assurance

A Design-Science-Informed Method for Verifying Effective Access Outcomes

Working manuscript v0.8.2 | Journal-neutral | Pre-evaluation | July 2026

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Public research overview

RESEARCH PROBLEM

Administrative completion does not necessarily establish effective-access outcomes

Organizations use lifecycle workflows, access reviews, remediation tickets, connector responses, and technical logs to govern access. These records can show that activity occurred without establishing that the intended access state was achieved or sustained.

Examples of the gap

- A revocation decision is recorded but not implemented.
- A connector reports success while access persists elsewhere.
- A direct entitlement is removed while inherited or delegated access remains.
- An account is disabled while active sessions, tokens, credentials, or automated recreation remain.
- A finding is closed without evidence that the relevant effective-access state changed.

Central research question

How can organizations establish and sustain an effective identity-hygiene program that governs human and non-human identities throughout their lifecycles and provides reliable assurance that access remains appropriate and remediation has been successfully completed?

Analytical focus: bounded, evidence-supported conclusions that disclose scope, assumptions, residual paths, uncertainty, and time limits rather than promising absolute certainty.

RESEARCH DESIGN

Integrative review, standards analysis, and design-science-informed artifact development

Evidence development

- Systematic integrative literature review
- Comparative analysis of authoritative standards and guidance
- Separate scholarly, authoritative, and practice corpora
- Traceability from evidence to design requirements
- Explicit treatment of contrary evidence, prior art, and boundary conditions

Proposed artifact components

- Technical remediation-state model
- Governance-closure model
- Assurance-claim structure
- Evidence-sufficiency rules
- Residual-path and defeater treatment
- Identity-type-specific application guidance
- Time-bounded sustainment requirements

Provisional contribution

The candidate contribution is narrower than a general IAM framework. It is an identity-specific outcome-assurance method intended to relate governance decisions, observable remediation states, evidence, residual access, closure authority, and sustainment. The contribution and novelty boundary remain subject to the formal review and independent evaluation.

CURRENT STATUS

Pre-evaluation manuscript - no effectiveness findings are reported

Provisionally completed

- Working manuscript v0.8.2
- Bibliographic detail and manuscript-citation hardening
- Canonical requirement traceability
- Internal evidence-defeater and boundary-condition audit
- Controlled research administration and change-control materials

Still incomplete

- Formal database-native review
- Independent screening audit
- Applicable ethics or oversight determination
- Independent content review
- Cognitive pilot
- Main expert evaluation
- Results, final limitations, and final conclusions

Claims boundary

The work is not represented as peer-reviewed, accepted, empirically validated, or proven effective in operating organizations. No human evaluation results have been collected or reported. Results and final conclusions remain intentionally withheld until the planned review and evaluation are completed.

PLANNED EVALUATION AND RESEARCHER

Evaluation is designed to test the artifact under controlled conditions

Planned sequence

- Independent content review
- Cognitive pilot testing
- Counterbalanced multidisciplinary expert scenario evaluation
- Assessment of clarity, relevance, completeness, feasibility, adaptability, and reviewer burden
- Comparison of unsupported-closure and residual-access identification against an ordinary professional-judgment baseline under the same facts

Researcher background

- Corrine Blackthorn
- 20+ years of IT experience
- Nearly seven years supporting enterprise IAM at Nike in a 70,000-80,000-user environment
- Experience in identity governance, access certification, audit liaison work, application onboarding, remediation, reporting, and technical documentation
- Independent research; not conducted on behalf of or endorsed by Nike or another former employer

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Public overview based on the controlled journal-neutral working manuscript v0.8.2. The full manuscript and restricted evaluation materials are not included in this public brief.

